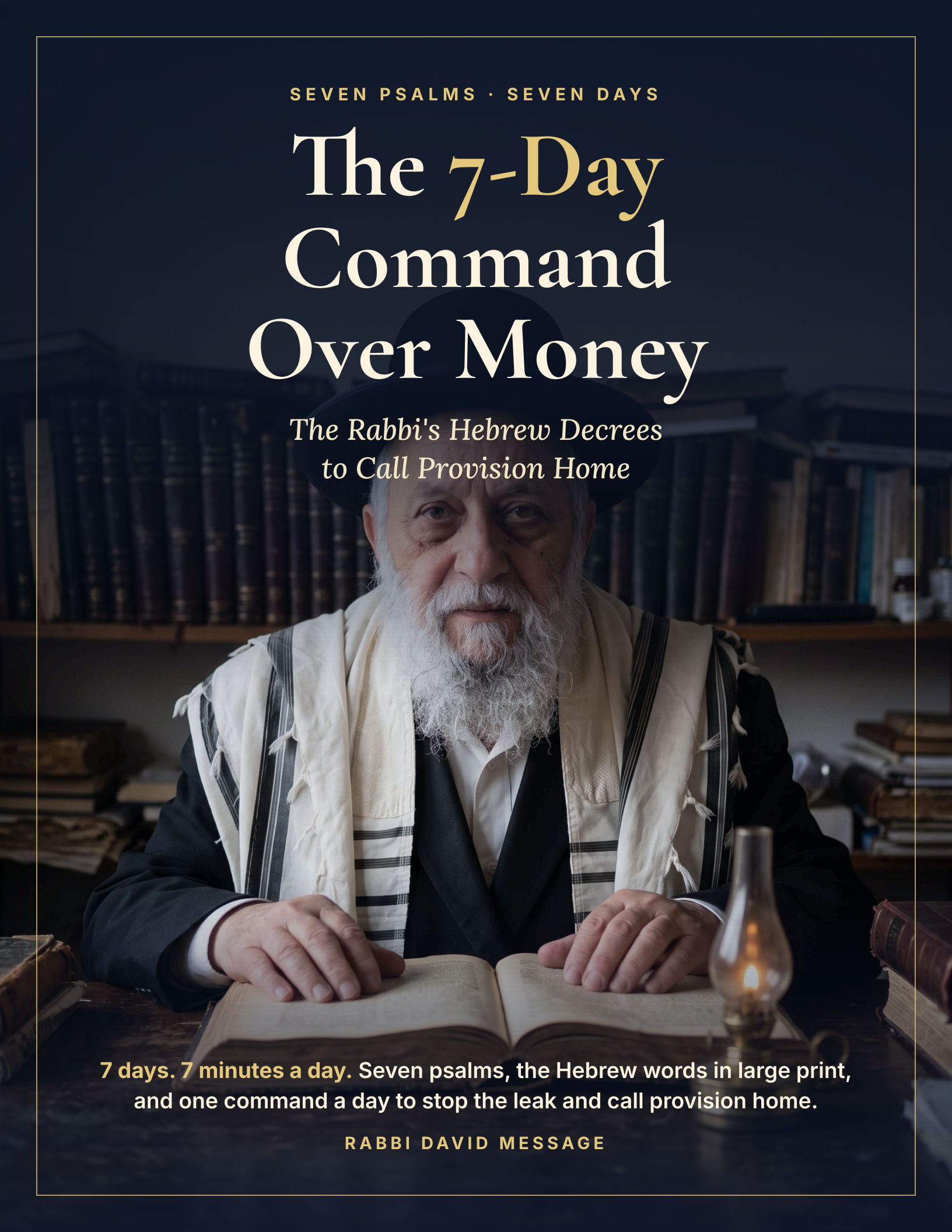
SEVEN PSALMS · SEVEN DAYS

The 7-Day Command Over Money

The Rabbi's Hebrew Decrees to Call Provision Home



7 days. 7 minutes a day. Seven psalms, the Hebrew words in large print, and one command a day to stop the leak and call provision home.

RABBI DAVID MESSAGE

The 7-Day Command Over Money

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Scripture quotations are from the King James Version, which is in the public domain. Hebrew text follows the Masoretic text. Short Talmud passages are translated for this book from the original Hebrew and Aramaic.

This book teaches prayers and habits from the Jewish tradition, with their sources, together with plain household steps. It does not promise any amount of money or any result by any date.

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Welcome: Seven Days, Seven Minutes

Maybe a bill came this week that you can't pay. Maybe the bills are paid but nothing is left, month after month, and you can't say where it went. Either way, you picked up this book because you want something to change, and you want to start today.

This book gives you something to do. Not a theory. Seven days, seven minutes a day, one psalm each day, one line of Hebrew to say slowly, and one short command to speak over your money and your house. Then one plain thing to do with your hands.

Why seven

The Torah counts in sevens. Six days of work and a seventh of rest. Six years of planting and a seventh of release, when a lender lets go of what his neighbor owes him (Deuteronomy 15). Seven days is long enough to build a habit and short enough to finish. You can do this.

The seven days are the method of this book. The psalms are not new. Each one has its own place in the prayers of the Jewish people, and you will learn that place on the day you say it.

How to use this book

- **Read Part One first.** It takes about an hour. It explains why the Bible says that money "answereth all things," and why the words you say inside your own house matter more than you think.
- **Then do the Seven Days in Part Two,** one chapter a day. Each day tells you its moment: when you wake up, or when you lie down at night. It gives you the full psalm

in the King James Version, the Hebrew words in large print with how to say them, the command of the day, and one task.

- **Part Three is for the days after.** What to do with debt, and what to do when money comes in.
- **The Daily Sheets** at the back of the book are meant to be printed. One page a day. Keep them in a folder by your bed.

What you'll see on the pages

- **The Hebrew words** are printed three ways: in Hebrew letters, in English letters you can read out loud, and broken into syllables. The syllable in CAPITALS is the one you lean on. If you never read Hebrew in your life, you can still say these words today.
- **The Command** is a short prayer you say aloud, in your own voice. You are not ordering Hashem around. You are telling your money and your house where they belong, under the One who gives it all.
- **Hold on** boxes are honest cautions. Read them.
- **The practical side** boxes give you one thing to do with your hands.
- **Rabbi David's notes** are plain advice for the moment you're in.
- **Checklists** end every chapter. Use a pencil.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

Don't rush this. Seven minutes said slowly is worth more than an hour said fast. Hashem is not in a hurry, and you don't need to be either.

One last word before we begin. Nothing in this book is a trick to make money appear. The tradition never taught that. It teaches that Hashem gives, that a person's words and habits can open the door or close it, and that prayer and honest work belong together. That is what you'll practice for seven days.

Let's begin.

— *Rabbi David*



PART ONE

The Ground

Before you say a single psalm, you need to know what you're doing and why. This part takes about an hour. It shows you what the Bible says about money that answers, about the words a house speaks, and about the door the widow shut before the oil began to flow. Read it once, slowly. Then you're ready for Day 1.

CHAPTER 1

Why Money Listens

✦

Most people treat money like the weather. It comes, it goes, and you just live with it. The Bible doesn't talk about money that way. It talks about money that answers.

The verse that started this book

Near the end of the book of Ecclesiastes, King Solomon writes a line most people skip:

> *"A feast is made for laughter, and wine maketh merry: but money answereth all things." (Ecclesiastes 10:19)*

In Hebrew the last words are short and strong.

ECCLESIASTES 10:19

וְהַכֶּסֶף יַעֲנֶה אֶת־הַכֹּל

Vehakesef ya'aneh et hakol.

veh-hah-KEH-sef · yah-ah-NEH · et hah-KOHL

"But money answereth all things."

The word *ya'aneh* means "will answer." It's the same root used when a person answers a call. Solomon is not saying money is everything. He's saying money responds. It goes where it is called. It answers to something.

So the question is: what is your money answering to right now?

What money answers to

Think about the last month. Where did your money go? Some of it you sent on purpose: rent, groceries, the electric bill. Some of it slipped away. A little here, a little there, and you can't remember where.

That second kind is the leak. It's the money that answered to habit, to worry, to a quick yes at the store, to the voice that says "just this once." Money always answers to something. When we don't call it, something else does.

The Torah puts it in a different way. Moses tells the people:

> *"The LORD shall command the blessing upon thee in thy storehouses, and in all that thou settest thine hand unto." (Deuteronomy 28:8)*

Look at the two places the blessing goes: your storehouses, and the work of your hands. The blessing comes from Hashem. It lands where you have put your hand. A blessing needs somewhere to land.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

Prayer without a plan is a wish. A plan without prayer is a gamble. This book asks you for both, seven minutes at a time.

The very next verse

Solomon doesn't stop at verse 19. The next line is a warning:

> *"Curse not the king, no not in thy thought; and curse not the rich in thy bedchamber: for a bird of the air shall carry the voice, and that which hath wings shall tell the matter." (Ecclesiastes 10:20)*

Right after "money answereth all things," Solomon talks about words. Not words said in the town square. Words said in your bedroom. Even words you only think. A bird carries them out.

Why put these two verses side by side? Because what you say about money, in private, is part of what your money answers to. The bitter word about the rich. The curse at the boss. The "we'll never have enough." It doesn't stay in the room.

That is the whole idea of the next chapter, and it is the first thing you will change.

Little by little, by the hand

One more verse belongs here, because it sets the pace for everything that follows.

> *"Wealth gotten by vanity shall be diminished: but he that gathereth by labour shall increase." (Proverbs 13:11)*

Where the King James says "by labour," the Hebrew says *al yad*: "by the hand," or "hand by hand." Little by little. Money that comes in a rush often leaves in a rush. Money gathered with your own hand, a piece at a time, grows.

That's why this book is seven small days and not one big night. You aren't looking for a jackpot. You are setting your house in order, so that what comes in stays, and what stays grows.

HOLD ON

This book will not tell you that a psalm makes money appear. The Bible doesn't promise that, and neither does the Jewish tradition. It teaches that Hashem gives, and that a person can open the door or close it. Seven days of opening the door is what you are about to do.

What changes in seven days

Here is what the seven days do, in plain terms:

- **You stop the leak.** You learn what your house says about money, and you change it. You see where the money goes.
- **You call provision home.** Each morning or night you say a psalm of provision, one Hebrew line, and the command of the day, out loud.
- **You do one thing with your hands.** Each day has a task: open the envelope you've been avoiding, write the list, give a coin.

THE PRACTICAL SIDE

Get a plain notebook and a pencil today. You'll use them every day of the seven. If you can print, print the Daily Sheets at the back of this book now, so they're ready.

BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

- [ ] I read Ecclesiastes 10:19 and said "Vehakesef ya'aneh et hakol" out loud once.
- [ ] I can name one place my money went last month that I didn't choose.
- [ ] I have a notebook and pencil for the seven days.
- [ ] I printed the Daily Sheets, or marked the page where they are.



A notebook, a pencil and the Book of Psalms. That's all you need for the seven days.

CHAPTER 2

Seal the Vessel: Words That Are Not Said in This House

✦

Every leak starts somewhere small. In a house that's short of money, it often starts with the mouth. Before you call provision in, you close the cracks it would run out of.

The widow who shut the door

In the Second Book of Kings there is a woman in real trouble. Her husband has died. He was a man who feared the LORD, and still he left a debt. Now the creditor is coming to take her two sons as servants to pay it.

She goes to the prophet Elisha. He asks her one question: "What hast thou in the house?" She says she has nothing, "save a pot of oil." (2 Kings 4:2)

Elisha tells her to borrow empty vessels from all her neighbors, "borrow not a few." Then he gives her an instruction that's easy to read past:

> *"And when thou art come in, thou shalt shut the door upon thee and upon thy sons, and shalt pour out into all those vessels." (2 Kings 4:4)*

She shuts the door. She pours. The oil keeps flowing as long as there are vessels. When the last vessel is full, "the oil stayed." Then Elisha says: "Go, sell the oil, and pay thy debt, and live thou and thy children of the rest." (2 Kings 4:7)

2 KINGS 4:4

וְסָגַרְתְּ הַדֶּלֶת בַּעֲדֵךְ וּבְעַד־בָּנַיִךְ

Vesagart hadelet ba'adech uv'ad banayich.

veh-sah-GART · hah-DEH-let · bah-ah-DEKH · oov-AHD bah-NAI-ikh

"Thou shalt shut the door upon thee and upon thy sons."

Notice three things.

1. She started with what she had. Not much. A pot of oil.
2. She brought vessels. The blessing needed somewhere to go.
3. She shut the door. What happened inside her house stayed inside her house.

Shutting the door is the first step of this book. It means sealing your house: guarding what is said inside it, and what goes out of it.

Never open your mouth to trouble

The Talmud has a short teaching that many Jewish families still repeat, even those who never opened the page. In tractate Berakhot (19a), Rabbi Shimon ben Lakish says, and it was also taught in the name of Rabbi Yosei:

> *"A person should never open his mouth to the Satan."*

The Talmud explains it plainly: don't say out loud that disaster is coming. Don't invite it with your words. Don't leave room for it.

Put that next to Solomon's bird that carries words from the bedroom, and you have a rule for the house: **some words are not said here.**

The words that are not said in this house

These are the sentences that leak money. Read them slowly and be honest about which ones you say.

- **"We're broke."** Said every day, it stops being a fact and becomes a name the house wears.
- **"We'll never get out of this."** "Never" is a door shut from the wrong side.
- **"Money is dirty."** Psalm 112 praises the man who "sheweth favour, and lendeth." You can't lend what you despise. Money is a tool in the hand of the one who uses it.
- **Curses on the rich, the boss or the bank.** Solomon names this one himself: "curse not the rich in thy bedchamber."
- **"I can't afford anything."** Often it's true for today. Said as a life sentence, it's not.
- **"It's no use."** Said before trying, it's a reason not to try.

What you say instead

Shutting the door doesn't mean pretending. Hashem doesn't need you to lie to Him. If there's no money for the gas bill, there is no money for the gas bill. The change is in how you say it.

Instead of this	Say this
"We're broke."	"Right now we have less than we need. Hashem provides."
"We'll never get out of this."	"We're getting out of this one step at a time."
"Money is dirty."	"Money is a tool. I'll use it well."
"Those rich people..."	(Say nothing. Let the bird fly empty.)
"I can't afford anything."	"That isn't in this month's plan."

Instead of this	Say this
"It's no use."	"I'll do the next small thing."



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

You don't have to feel it to say it. Say the true sentence anyway. The feelings will come and sit down at the table after a few days.

The rule of the closed door

Here is the rule for the seven days. Write it on a card and put it on the refrigerator.

THE RULE OF THIS HOUSE

In this house we don't curse our money, our work or the people who have more than we do. We tell the truth about what we have, and we thank Hashem for it. What we ask for, we ask Hashem. What comes in, we guard.

If you live with a spouse or family, tell them about the rule. You don't need to preach. Just say: "For one week, let's try not to say these things." If they won't, keep the rule yourself. One person shutting the door still shuts it.

HOLD ON

Sealing the vessel is about words of cursing and despair. It is not about hiding problems from your family. If there's a debt your spouse doesn't know about, tell them, calmly, this week. A secret debt is the biggest crack in any vessel.

Find the leak

The widow knew exactly what she had: one pot of oil. Most of us don't. So the second half of sealing the vessel is to look.

STEP BY STEP

1. In your notebook, draw a line down the middle of one page. On the left write "What came in." On the right write "What went out."
2. Every evening of the seven days, write down every dollar that left your hands or your account that day. Coffee, gas, the pharmacy, the card that renews by itself. Everything.
3. Don't judge it yet. Just write it.
4. On the evening of Day 7, circle the things you didn't choose on purpose. That's your leak.

THE PRACTICAL SIDE

The leak list costs nothing and takes two minutes a night. Many people find a charge they forgot about, a subscription, a fee, a habit. You can't close a crack you can't see.

Bring your vessels

Elisha told the widow to borrow empty vessels, "not a few." She had to make room for what was coming.

Your vessel for the seven days is simple. Find an envelope or a jar. Write nothing on it. Put it in a drawer, not on display. Over the seven days, every coin or bill you save from the leak, or that comes in unexpected, goes into it. In Chapter 11 you'll learn what to do with it. For now, just have it ready, and shut the drawer.

BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

- [ ] I read the story of the widow (2 Kings 4:1-7).
- [ ] I wrote "The Rule of This House" on a card and put it where I'll see it.
- [ ] I told the people I live with about the rule, or decided to keep it myself.
- [ ] I set up the leak page in my notebook.
- [ ] I have an envelope or jar ready, in a drawer.



The widow shut the door and poured. A sealed house keeps what comes in.



Some words are not said in this house. Others are said every day, slowly.



PART TWO

The Seven Days

One chapter a day, seven days in a row. Each day has its moment, its psalm, its Hebrew words in large print, its command and one task for your hands. Seven minutes for the prayer, a few more for the task. If you miss a day, don't start over. Pick up where you left off and finish.

CHAPTER 3 · DAY 1

Psalm 112, the House Where Wealth Stays

✦

Day 1 starts in the morning, before the mail and before the phone. Today you say the psalm that speaks of "wealth and riches" in a house, and you look at every bill you've been afraid to open.

YOUR MOMENT: MORNING

As soon as you're up and dressed, before you check the mail, the phone or the news. Psalm 92 says it is good "to shew forth thy lovingkindness in the morning." The first words of the day set the tone for the rest of it.

How every day works

Before the first psalm, here is the pattern you'll follow all seven days. It takes about seven minutes.

STEP BY STEP

1. Sit down somewhere quiet with this book, your notebook and a pencil. Take one slow breath.
2. Read the psalm of the day out loud, slowly. About three minutes.
3. Say the Hebrew words of the day three times, slowly, following the syllables. About one minute.
4. Say the Command of the day out loud, in your own voice. About one minute.

5. In your notebook, write one line: what you are asking Hashem for today, and what you will do with your hands today.
6. Sit for a moment in silence and say "thank You." Then go do the task.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

If you can only read slowly, read slowly. If your voice is weak, whisper. What matters is that your lips move and your heart is on the words.

Why Psalm 112

Psalm 112 is short, ten verses, and it describes one kind of person from top to bottom: the one who "feareth the LORD" and "delighteth greatly in his commandments." It says what his house is like. In the middle of it is the verse this whole day is built on:

> *"Wealth and riches shall be in his house: and his righteousness endureth for ever." (Psalm 112:3)*

Look at what the same psalm says about how this man handles money. He "sheweth favour, and lendeth: he will guide his affairs with discretion" (verse 5). "He hath dispersed, he hath given to the poor" (verse 9). And: "He shall not be afraid of evil tidings: his heart is fixed, trusting in the LORD" (verse 7).

So wealth in this psalm isn't luck. It lives with a man who gives, who lends, who manages his affairs with care, and who isn't afraid to hear bad news. That last one is today's task.

Read it aloud

PSALM 112 · KING JAMES VERSION

[1] Praise ye the LORD. Blessed is the man that feareth the LORD, that delighteth greatly in his commandments. [2] His seed shall be mighty upon earth: the generation of the upright shall be blessed. [3] Wealth and riches shall be in his house: and his righteousness endureth for ever. [4] Unto the upright there ariseth light in the darkness: he is gracious, and full of compassion, and righteous. [5] A good man sheweth favour, and lendeth: he will guide his affairs with discretion. [6] Surely he shall not be moved for ever: the righteous shall be in everlasting remembrance. [7] He shall not be afraid of evil tidings: his heart is fixed, trusting in the LORD. [8] His heart is established, he shall not be afraid, until he see his desire upon his enemies. [9] He hath dispersed, he hath given to the poor; his righteousness endureth for ever; his horn shall be exalted with honour. [10] The wicked shall see it, and be grieved; he shall gnash with his teeth, and melt away: the desire of the wicked shall perish.

The words of Day 1

THE WORDS OF DAY 1 · PSALM 112:3

הוֹן־וָעֹשֶׁר בְּבֵיתוֹ וְצִדְקָתוֹ עֹמֶדֶת לָעַד

Hon va'osher beveito, vetzidkato omedet la'ad.

HOHN vah-OH-sher · beh-vay-TOH · veh-tzeed-kah-TOH · oh-MEH-det · lah-AHD

"Wealth and riches shall be in his house: and his righteousness endureth for ever."

Say it three times. *Hon* is wealth. *Osher* is riches. *Beveito* is "in his house." *Tzidkato* is "his righteousness," from the same root as *tzedakah*, giving to the poor. In the Hebrew, wealth in the house and giving stand in the same sentence.

The Command of Day 1

THE COMMAND OF DAY 1

Hashem, Your word says, "Wealth and riches shall be in his house." I open this house to Your blessing. I am not afraid of the news in these envelopes. My heart is fixed, trusting in You. Every dollar that comes into this house, I will guide with care, and from it I will give. Hon va'osher beveito.

Today's task: open every envelope

"He shall not be afraid of evil tidings." For many people, the evil tidings are sitting in a drawer, in envelopes nobody wants to open.

STEP BY STEP

1. Gather every unopened envelope, past-due notice and letter from a bank, a collector or a utility. Check the drawers, the car, the counter.
2. Open them all, one by one. Don't stop to worry. Just open.
3. In your notebook, write a list: who it's from, how much it says, and the date it's due.
4. Put all of them, opened, in one folder. That folder is now your "known" pile. It is no longer a fear in the dark.

THE PRACTICAL SIDE

This is the most important task of the whole week. You can't pray over a bill you won't look at. Most people feel lighter the moment the last envelope is open, even before a single bill is paid.

HOLD ON

If any letter says a utility will be shut off, or a court date, call the number on it today. Ask what your options are. Don't wait for Day 6.

DAY 1 DONE

- [ ] I read Psalm 112 out loud in the morning.
- [ ] I said "Hon va'osher beveito" three times.
- [ ] I said the Command of Day 1.
- [ ] I opened every envelope and wrote the list.
- [ ] I wrote today's spending on my leak page tonight.



"He shall not be afraid of evil tidings." Day 1: open every envelope.

CHAPTER 4 · DAY 2

Psalm 65, the One Who Crowns the Year

✦

Yesterday you faced what goes out. Today you look at what comes in. Psalm 65 is a psalm of rain, of fields and of a full year, and today you'll learn the "rains" of your own house: the days money arrives.

> **YOUR MOMENT: MORNING**
> After you're up, before breakfast if you can. Psalm 65 itself praises the One who makes "the outgoings of the morning and evening to rejoice" (verse 8).

Why Psalm 65

Psalm 65 is a farmer's psalm. It sees the whole year from the field. It says to Hashem: "Thou visitest the earth, and waterest it" (verse 9). "Thou preparest them corn." "Thou waterest the ridges thereof abundantly... thou makest it soft with showers" (verse 10). And then the line we'll say today:

> *"Thou crownest the year with thy goodness; and thy paths drop fatness." (Psalm 65:11)*

A farmer can't make it rain. But he knows when the rains come, and he's ready with plowed ground when they do. That's the picture for today. You can't control everything that comes in. You can know when it comes, and be ready.

Read it aloud

PSALM 65 · KING JAMES VERSION

[1] Praise waiteth for thee, O God, in Sion: and unto thee shall the vow be performed. [2] O thou that hearest prayer, unto thee shall all flesh come. [3] Iniquities prevail against me: as for our transgressions, thou shalt purge them away. [4] Blessed is the man whom thou choosest, and causest to approach unto thee, that he may dwell in thy courts: we shall be satisfied with the goodness of thy house, even of thy holy temple. [5] By terrible things in righteousness wilt thou answer us, O God of our salvation; who art the confidence of all the ends of the earth, and of them that are afar off upon the sea: [6] Which by his strength setteth fast the mountains; being girded with power: [7] Which stilleth the noise of the seas, the noise of their waves, and the tumult of the people. [8] They also that dwell in the uttermost parts are afraid at thy tokens: thou makest the outgoings of the morning and evening to rejoice. [9] Thou visitest the earth, and waterest it: thou greatly enrichest it with the river of God, which is full of water: thou preparest them corn, when thou hast so provided for it. [10] Thou waterest the ridges thereof abundantly: thou settlest the furrows thereof: thou makest it soft with showers: thou blessest the springing thereof. [11] Thou crownest the year with thy goodness; and thy paths drop fatness. [12] They drop upon the pastures of the wilderness: and the little hills rejoice on every side. [13] The pastures are clothed with flocks; the valleys also are covered over with corn; they shout for joy, they also sing.

The words of Day 2

THE WORDS OF DAY 2 · PSALM 65:11 (HEBREW VERSE 12)

עִטַּרְתָּ שְׁנַת טוּבָתֶךָ וּמַעְגָּלֶיךָ יִרְעֲפוּן דָּשֶׁן

Itarta shenat tovatecha, uma'galecha yir'afun dashen.

ee-TAR-tah · sheh-NAHT · toh-vah-TEH-khah · oo-mahg-gah-LEH-khah · yeer-ah-FOON · DAH-shen

"Thou crownest the year with thy goodness; and thy paths drop fatness."

Itarta is "You crowned," from *atarah*, a crown. *Shenat tovatecha* is "the year of Your goodness." You are asking Hashem to put a crown on this year, the one you're in right now, not some year far away.

The Command of Day 2

THE COMMAND OF DAY 2

Hashem, You crown the year with Your goodness. Crown this year in this house. You water the fields in their season. Let the rains of this house come on time, and let me be ready for them. What comes in, I will receive with thanks and set in its place. Itarta shenat tovatecha.

Today's task: write your rain calendar

STEP BY STEP

1. On a clean page of your notebook, write the twelve months down the side.
2. For each month, write every day money comes in: pension, Social Security, a paycheck, rent from a tenant, a regular gift from family. Write the source and the day.
3. Next to it, write the bills that are due in the same week.
4. Look for the week where too much goes out before the money comes in. That's the dry week. Circle it.
5. Write one idea for that week: move a due date, set aside a little the week before, or ask the lender to change the date. You'll make that call on Day 6.

THE PRACTICAL SIDE

Many companies will move a bill's due date if you ask. It costs nothing to ask. Moving one bill to the week after your money arrives can stop a late fee every single month.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

Don't be embarrassed if the calendar looks thin. A farmer with one field still plants it. You're learning your field.

DAY 2 DONE

- [ ] I read Psalm 65 out loud in the morning.
- [ ] I said "Itarta shenat tovatecha" three times.
- [ ] I said the Command of Day 2.
- [ ] I wrote my rain calendar and circled the dry week.
- [ ] I wrote today's spending on my leak page tonight.



"Thou visitest the earth, and waterest it." Learn when the rains of your house come.

CHAPTER 5 · DAY 3

Psalm 23, I Shall Not Want

✦

Day 3 moves to the night. Many money worries are loudest at bedtime. Tonight you'll go to sleep with the most famous psalm of all, and before you do, you'll count what Hashem has already put in your house.

> **YOUR MOMENT: AT BEDTIME**
>
> When you're ready for bed, lights low, before you lie down. The Torah tells us to speak the words of Hashem "when thou liest down, and when thou risest up" (Deuteronomy 6:7). And Psalm 23 itself begins with rest: "He maketh me to lie down in green pastures."

Why Psalm 23

Almost everyone knows the first line by heart. But read it again as if you'd never heard it:

> *"The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want." (Psalm 23:1)*

"I shall not want" is not "I shall have everything." It means "I shall not lack." A shepherd doesn't give his sheep a palace. He makes sure they have grass, water, a path and protection. Exactly what they need, when they need it.

Then the psalm moves to the table: "Thou preparest a table before me in the presence of mine enemies... my cup runneth over" (verse 5). The table is already set. The cup is already full. Tonight's task is to see it.

Read it aloud

PSALM 23 · KING JAMES VERSION

[1] The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want. [2] He maketh me to lie down in green pastures: he leadeth me beside the still waters. [3] He restoreth my soul: he leadeth me in the paths of righteousness for his name's sake. [4] Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil: for thou art with me; thy rod and thy staff they comfort me. [5] Thou preparest a table before me in the presence of mine enemies: thou anointest my head with oil; my cup runneth over. [6] Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life: and I will dwell in the house of the LORD for ever.

The words of Day 3

THE WORDS OF DAY 3 · PSALM 23:1

יְהוָה רֹעִי לֹא אֶחְסָר

Adonai ro'i, lo echsar.

ah-doh-NYE · roh-EE · LOH · ekh-SAHR

"The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want."

Four words. *Adonai*, the LORD. *Ro'i*, my shepherd. *Lo*, not. *Echsar*, I will lack. Say them slowly three times. These are good words to say again if you wake up in the night.

The Command of Day 3

THE COMMAND OF DAY 3

Hashem, You are my shepherd. I shall not lack. You have already set a table in this house, and tonight I count it with thanks. I lie down in peace. I leave tomorrow's bills in Your hand until morning. Adonai ro'i, lo echsar.

Today's task: what hast thou in the house?

Elisha asked the widow one question before anything else: "What hast thou in the house?" Tonight, before you say the psalm, you answer it.

STEP BY STEP

1. On a new page, write "What I have in the house."
2. Write the food in the pantry and the freezer. You may be surprised how many meals are there.
3. Write the things you own and don't use: a tool, furniture, a second car, a collection. Mark the ones you'd be willing to sell.
4. Write what you can do: a skill, a trade, a talent, time. Something someone might pay for, or trade for.
5. Write the people who would help you if you asked.
6. Read the list once. Then say Psalm 23.

THE PRACTICAL SIDE

For the next week, plan meals from what's already in the pantry before buying more. It's the simplest way to stop a leak that feels like "groceries" on paper.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

The widow said she had nothing, and then she remembered the oil. Most people who say "I have nothing" have a pot of oil somewhere. Find yours.

DAY 3 DONE

- [ ] I wrote "What I have in the house."
- [ ] I read Psalm 23 out loud at bedtime.
- [ ] I said "Adonai ro'i, lo echsar" three times.
- [ ] I said the Command of Day 3.
- [ ] I wrote today's spending on my leak page.



"He maketh me to lie down." Day 3 is said at bedtime.

CHAPTER 6 · DAY 4

Psalm 91, the Secret Place

✦

Day 4 is also said at night. If there's a money fear that wakes you at three in the morning, tonight you give it a name, write down the first step, and put it under the shadow of the Almighty.

YOUR MOMENT: AT BEDTIME

At night, the last thing before you lie down. Psalm 91 is part of the Shema said before sleep in the Jewish prayer book, the Siddur. Jews still go to sleep with these words.

Why Psalm 91

Psalm 91 is a psalm of protection. It speaks of a "secret place," a shadow, wings and a shield:

> *"He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty." (Psalm 91:1)*

It names the fears of the night directly: "Thou shalt not be afraid for the terror by night" (verse 5). And it names a trap: "Surely he shall deliver thee from the snare of the fowler" (verse 3). A fowler is a bird-catcher. He sets a snare where the bird doesn't see it.

That's two things for tonight. The fear that comes by night, and the snare you don't see coming.

Read it aloud

PSALM 91 · KING JAMES VERSION

[1] He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty. [2] I will say of the LORD, He is my refuge and my fortress: my God; in him will I trust. [3] Surely he shall deliver thee from the snare of the fowler, and from the noisome pestilence. [4] He shall cover thee with his feathers, and under his wings shalt thou trust: his truth shall be thy shield and buckler. [5] Thou shalt not be afraid for the terror by night; nor for the arrow that flieth by day; [6] Nor for the pestilence that walketh in darkness; nor for the destruction that wasteth at noonday. [7] A thousand shall fall at thy side, and ten thousand at thy right hand; but it shall not come nigh thee. [8] Only with thine eyes shalt thou behold and see the reward of the wicked. [9] Because thou hast made the LORD, which is my refuge, even the most High, thy habitation; [10] There shall no evil befall thee, neither shall any plague come nigh thy dwelling. [11] For he shall give his angels charge over thee, to keep thee in all thy ways. [12] They shall bear thee up in their hands, lest thou dash thy foot against a stone. [13] Thou shalt tread upon the lion and adder: the young lion and the dragon shalt thou trample under feet. [14] Because he hath set his love upon me, therefore will I deliver him: I will set him on high, because he hath known my name. [15] He shall call upon me, and I will answer him: I will be with him in trouble; I will deliver him, and honour him. [16] With long life will I satisfy him, and shew him my salvation.

The words of Day 4

THE WORDS OF DAY 4 · PSALM 91:1

יֹשֵׁב בְּסֵתֶר עֶלְיוֹן בְּצֵל שַׁדַּי יִתְלוֹנָן

Yoshev beseter Elyon, betzel Shaddai yitlonan.

yoh-SHEV · beh-SEH-ter · el-YOHN · beh-TZEL · shah-DYE · yeet-loh-NAHN

"He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty."

Yoshev means "one who sits" or "dwells." *Beseter* is "in the hidden place." *Elyon* is "the Most High." *Betzel Shaddai* is "in the shadow of the Almighty." *Yitlonan* is "will rest for the night." The last word of the verse is a word for spending the night. It's a bedtime verse.

The Command of Day 4

THE COMMAND OF DAY 4

Hashem, I dwell in Your secret place tonight. I name my fear and I put it in Your hand. Deliver this house from the snare of the fowler: from the trap I don't see, the false call, the bad deal. I will not be afraid of the terror by night. I rest under the shadow of the Almighty. Yoshev beseter Elyon.

Today's task: name the fear, and guard the door

STEP BY STEP

1. Before the psalm, write at the top of a page: "The money fear that wakes me up." Write it in one sentence.
2. Under it, write the first small step you could take about it. Only the first one. A phone call, a question, a list.
3. Close the notebook. The fear is on paper now. It doesn't need to stay in your head.
4. Then guard against the snare. Say this rule out loud and keep it: I never give my bank number, card number, Social Security number or passwords to anyone who calls, texts or emails me first. If someone says they're from my bank, I hang up and call the number on the back of my card.
5. Say Psalm 91, the words and the Command, and go to sleep.

HOLD ON

Scammers often call older people pretending to be a bank, a government office or a grandchild in trouble, and they push you to act fast. A real bank or agency won't be angry if you hang up and call back. Speed is the snare. Slow down.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

Fear grows in the dark and shrinks on paper. Write it down, give it to Hashem, and let tomorrow's version of you deal with the first step.

DAY 4 DONE

- [ ] I wrote my money fear and its first step.
- [ ] I said the snare rule out loud.
- [ ] I read Psalm 91 out loud at bedtime.
- [ ] I said "Yoshev beseter Elyon" three times.
- [ ] I said the Command of Day 4.
- [ ] I wrote today's spending on my leak page.

CHAPTER 7 · DAY 5

Psalm 24, the Earth Is the LORD's

✦

Day 5 goes back to the morning, with the psalm the Levites sang on the first day of every week in the Temple. It reminds you who owns everything, and asks you for clean hands. Today you'll clean out one charge that's taking money without asking.

YOUR MOMENT: MORNING

In the morning, as you start the day. The Mishnah, in tractate Tamid, lists the psalm the Levites sang each day of the week in the Temple. On the first day of the week, it was Psalm 24. It's a psalm for beginnings.

Why Psalm 24

It opens with a sentence that changes how you see your wallet:

> *"The earth is the LORD'S, and the fulness thereof; the world, and they that dwell therein." (Psalm 24:1)*

If the earth and all that fills it belong to Hashem, then the money in your account is His too. You're the manager, not the owner. That's not a burden. It's a relief. The Owner has more than enough.

Then the psalm asks a question: "Who shall ascend into the hill of the LORD?" And it answers: "He that hath clean hands, and a pure heart... He shall receive the blessing from the LORD" (verses 3–5). Clean hands receive the blessing.

Read it aloud

PSALM 24 · KING JAMES VERSION

[1]The earth is the LORD'S, and the fulness thereof; the world, and they that dwell therein. [2]For he hath founded it upon the seas, and established it upon the floods. [3]Who shall ascend into the hill of the LORD? or who shall stand in his holy place? [4]He that hath clean hands, and a pure heart; who hath not lifted up his soul unto vanity, nor sworn deceitfully. [5]He shall receive the blessing from the LORD, and righteousness from the God of his salvation. [6]This is the generation of them that seek him, that seek thy face, O Jacob. Selah. [7]Lift up your heads, O ye gates; and be ye lift up, ye everlasting doors; and the King of glory shall come in. [8]Who is this King of glory? The LORD strong and mighty, the LORD mighty in battle. [9]Lift up your heads, O ye gates; even lift them up, ye everlasting doors; and the King of glory shall come in. [10]Who is this King of glory? The LORD of hosts, he is the King of glory. Selah.

The words of Day 5

THE WORDS OF DAY 5 · PSALM 24:1

לַיהוָה הָאָרֶץ וּמְלוֹאָהּ תֵּבֵל וְיֹשְׁבֵי בָהּ

LaAdonai ha'aretz umelo'ah, tevel veyoshvei vah.

lah-ah-doh-NYE · hah-AH-retz · oo-meh-loh-AH · teh-VEL · veh-yohsh-VAY · VAH

"The earth is the LORD'S, and the fulness thereof; the world, and they that dwell therein."

LaAdonai is "to the LORD," "belongs to the LORD." *Ha'aretz* is "the earth." *Umelo'ah* is "and all that fills it." Say it as a statement of fact, because it is one.

The Command of Day 5

THE COMMAND OF DAY 5

Hashem, the earth is Yours and all that fills it. The money in this house is Yours, and I am its manager. I clean my hands today: what doesn't belong here goes out, and what I owe, I will pay. Let this house receive the blessing from the LORD. LaAdonai ha'aretz umelo'ah.

Today's task: clean hands

"Clean hands" means two things today. First, nothing in your money should be taking without permission. Second, nothing you owe a person should be forgotten.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open your leak page and your bank or card statement for the last month.
2. Find every charge that repeats by itself: subscriptions, memberships, apps, insurance add-ons, a service you no longer use.
3. Choose at least one you don't need, and cancel it today.
4. Then ask yourself: do I owe money to a person, a friend, a relative or a neighbor, that I've let slide? Write their name. Plan to pay something, even a little, or at least to call and say you haven't forgotten.

THE PRACTICAL SIDE

Repeating charges are the quietest leak of all, because they never ask again. Whatever you save from the one you cancel goes into your envelope in the drawer.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

A debt to a friend weighs on a house more than a debt to a bank. Pay the person first, even if it's a small piece.

DAY 5 DONE

- [ ] I read Psalm 24 out loud in the morning.
- [ ] I said "LaAdonai ha'aretz umelo'ah" three times.
- [ ] I said the Command of Day 5.
- [ ] I cancelled at least one repeating charge.
- [ ] I wrote the name of anyone I owe, and a plan.
- [ ] I wrote today's spending on my leak page tonight.



Day 5: clean hands. Cancel one charge that takes without asking.

CHAPTER 8 · DAY 6

Psalm 145, You Open Your Hand

✦

Day 6 is the heart of the week. Psalm 145 is the psalm of provision that Jews say three times every day. Today you'll say it in the morning, say its most important verse twice more, and make the phone call you've been putting off.

> **YOUR MOMENT: MORNING, AND TWICE MORE TODAY**
> Say the whole psalm in the morning. Then, at midday and in the evening, say only verse 16, the Hebrew and the English, slowly. That's less than a minute each.

Why Psalm 145

The Talmud, in tractate Berakhot (4b), teaches that anyone who says Psalm 145 three times every day is assured a place in the World to Come. It asks why this psalm and not another. The answer: it runs through the whole Hebrew alphabet, and it speaks of Hashem giving food to every living thing. It's the psalm of provision.

Jews know it as *Ashrei*, from the verse "Happy [ashrei] are those who dwell in Your house," which is said just before it. Its center is this verse:

> *"Thou openest thine hand, and satisfiest the desire of every living thing." (Psalm 145:16)*

The Shulchan Aruch, the code of Jewish law, says a person must concentrate when he says this verse, and that if he said it without paying attention, he goes back and says it again (Orach Chayim 51:7). It's that important. Today you'll say it slowly, three times a day, with your whole attention.

Read it aloud

PSALM 145 · KING JAMES VERSION

[1] I will extol thee, my God, O king; and I will bless thy name for ever and ever. [2] Every day will I bless thee; and I will praise thy name for ever and ever. [3] Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised; and his greatness is unsearchable. [4] One generation shall praise thy works to another, and shall declare thy mighty acts. [5] I will speak of the glorious honour of thy majesty, and of thy wondrous works. [6] And men shall speak of the might of thy terrible acts: and I will declare thy greatness. [7] They shall abundantly utter the memory of thy great goodness, and shall sing of thy righteousness. [8] The LORD is gracious, and full of compassion; slow to anger, and of great mercy. [9] The LORD is good to all: and his tender mercies are over all his works. [10] All thy works shall praise thee, O LORD; and thy saints shall bless thee. [11] They shall speak of the glory of thy kingdom, and talk of thy power; [12] To make known to the sons of men his mighty acts, and the glorious majesty of his kingdom. [13] Thy kingdom is an everlasting kingdom, and thy dominion endureth throughout all generations. [14] The LORD upholdeth all that fall, and raiseth up all those that be bowed down. [15] The eyes of all wait upon thee; and thou givest them their meat in due season. [16] Thou openest thine hand, and satisfiest the desire of every living thing. [17] The LORD is righteous in all his ways, and holy in all his works. [18] The LORD is nigh unto all them that call upon him, to all that call upon him in truth. [19] He will fulfil the desire of them that fear him: he also will hear their cry, and will save them. [20] The LORD preserveth all them that love him: but all the wicked will he destroy. [21] My mouth shall speak the praise of the LORD: and let all flesh bless his holy name for ever and ever.

The words of Day 6

THE WORDS OF DAY 6 · PSALM 145:16

פּוֹתֵחַ אֶת־יָדֶךָ וּמַשְׂבִּיעַ לְכָל־חַי רָצוֹן

Pote'ach et yadecha, umasbia lechol chai ratzon.

poh-TEH-akh · et yah-DEH-khah · oo-mahs-BEE-ah · leh-KHOL KHAI · rah-TZOHN

"Thou openest thine hand, and satisfiest the desire of every living thing."

Pote'ach is "You open." *Yadecha* is "Your hand." *Umasbia* is "and You satisfy." *Lechol chai* is "every living thing." *Ratzon* is "desire," or "favor." If you like, open your own hands, palms up, as you say this verse. It's a quiet way to remember who is giving and who is receiving.

The Command of Day 6

THE COMMAND OF DAY 6

Hashem, You open Your hand and satisfy every living thing. I am a living thing in this house, and I hold my hands open to You. You are near to all who call on You in truth. Today I call on You in truth, and I call on people in truth, without shame. Pote'ach et yadecha, umasbia lechol chai ratzon.

Today's task: the honest call

Verse 18 says, "The LORD is nigh unto all them that call upon him... in truth." Today you call on Hashem in the morning. Then you make one honest call to a person.

STEP BY STEP

1. Look back at your notes: the dry week from Day 2, the fear and its first step from Day 4, the overdue bills from Day 1.
2. Pick the one call that would help the most. It might be the lender, to ask about a hardship plan or a lower payment. The utility, to ask about a payment plan or a due date. A local office, to ask what help you might qualify for. A customer or an employer, to ask for work.
3. Write down what you'll say in two sentences. Tell the truth: what's happening, and what you're asking for.
4. Make the call. Write down the name of the person you spoke to, the date, and what they said.
5. If the answer is no, ask: "Is there anyone else I can speak with, or anything else you can offer?"

THE PRACTICAL SIDE

Many lenders and utilities have hardship programs they don't advertise. You usually only hear about them if you ask. The call is free. Not calling can cost a great deal.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

The verse says "in truth." Don't make your situation sound better or worse than it is. Plain truth, said calmly, opens more doors than tears or pride.

DAY 6 DONE

- [ ] I read Psalm 145 out loud in the morning.
- [ ] I said "Pote'ach et yadecha" at midday.
- [ ] I said "Pote'ach et yadecha" in the evening.
- [ ] I said the Command of Day 6.
- [ ] I made the honest call and wrote down what was said.
- [ ] I wrote today's spending on my leak page tonight.



"Thou openest thine hand." Day 6 is said three times.

CHAPTER 9 · DAY 7

Psalm 37, Never Forsaken

✦

The seventh day is for looking back and giving thanks. You say it at night, after your evening meal, with a verse that Jews say at the end of the blessing after eating. Then you give your first coin, and you look at what the week showed you.

> **YOUR MOMENT: AFTER THE EVENING MEAL**
> After supper, at the table, before you get up. At the end of Birkat HaMazon, the blessing said after a meal, the Siddur includes two verses you already know: "Thou openest thine hand" from Psalm 145, and today's verse from Psalm 37.

Why Psalm 37

Psalm 37 is a long psalm. Today you'll read a short section of it, verses 23 to 29, which ends a week of seven psalms with a promise and a picture of a life:

> *"I have been young, and now am old; yet have I not seen the righteous forsaken, nor his seed begging bread." (Psalm 37:25)*

These are the words of someone who has lived. "I have been young, and now am old." He's looking back over a whole life. He doesn't say the righteous never had hard years. He says he never saw them *forsaken*. That's a different thing. Hard times came. Hashem didn't leave.

And look at the very next verse: "He is ever merciful, and lendeth; and his seed is blessed" (verse 26). Again, as in Psalm 112, the blessed man is one who gives and lends.

Read it aloud

PSALM 37:23–29 · KING JAMES VERSION

23 The steps of a good man are ordered by the LORD: and he delighteth in his way.
24 Though he fall, he shall not be utterly cast down: for the LORD upholdeth him with his hand. 25 I have been young, and now am old; yet have I not seen the righteous forsaken, nor his seed begging bread. 26 He is ever merciful, and lendeth; and his seed is blessed. 27 Depart from evil, and do good; and dwell for evermore. 28 For the LORD loveth judgment, and forsaketh not his saints; they are preserved for ever: but the seed of the wicked shall be cut off. 29 The righteous shall inherit the land, and dwell therein for ever.

The words of Day 7

THE WORDS OF DAY 7 · PSALM 37:25

נַעַר הָיִיתִי גַּם־זָקַנְתִּי וְלֹא־רָאִיתִי צַדִּיק נֶעֱזָב וְזַרְעוֹ מְבַקֶּשׁ־לָחֶם

Na'ar hayiti gam zakanti, velo ra'iti tzaddik ne'ezav, vezar'o mevakesh lachem.

NAH-ar hah-YEE-tee · gahm zah-KAHN-tee · veh-LOH rah-EE-tee · tzah-DEEK neh-eh-ZAHV · veh-zar-OH meh-vah-KESH LAH-khem

"I have been young, and now am old; yet have I not seen the righteous forsaken, nor his seed begging bread."

This is the longest line of the week, so take it in pieces. *Na'ar hayiti*, I was young. *Gam zakanti*, and I've grown old. *Velo ra'iti*, and I have not seen. *Tzaddik ne'ezav*, a righteous man forsaken. *Vezar'o mevakesh lachem*, or his children begging for bread. Say it once in pieces, then twice whole.

The Command of Day 7

THE COMMAND OF DAY 7

Hashem, I have been young, and now I am older, and You have not forsaken me. You have not forsaken this house. For seven days I opened the door, I sealed the vessel, and I called on You in truth. Before I ask for more, I give. Let the work of this week stand. Let my children never beg for bread. Na'ar hayiti gam zakanti.

Today's task: give first, then look back

In tractate Bava Batra (10a) the Talmud tells of Rabbi Elazar, who would first give a coin to a poor person, and only then pray. Tonight you do the same.

STEP BY STEP

1. Before you say the psalm, take one coin or bill, any amount, and set it aside for tzedakah, charity. You'll learn where to give it in Chapter 11.
2. Read Psalm 37:23–29, say the Hebrew, and say the Command.
3. Open your leak page. Read the whole week. Circle every expense you didn't choose on purpose.
4. Write the three biggest circles at the bottom of the page. These are the cracks in your vessel. Next week, close one of them.
5. Write one line: "This week I saw..." and finish the sentence with something good that happened. A call that went well, a bill that was less than you feared, a meal from the pantry, peace at night.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

Don't skip the last step. A person who only writes down his troubles thinks his life is only troubles. Write down the good too. It's just as true.

DAY 7 DONE

- [ ] I set aside a coin for tzedakah before praying.
- [ ] I read Psalm 37:23–29 out loud after the evening meal.
- [ ] I said "Na'ar hayiti gam zakanti" three times.
- [ ] I said the Command of Day 7.
- [ ] I circled the leaks and wrote the three biggest.
- [ ] I wrote one good thing I saw this week.



"I have not seen the righteous forsaken." Day 7: give first, then look back.



PART THREE

Keeping It

The seven days opened the door. This part is about what comes after: the debt that's still there, and the money that starts to come in. One chapter for each, and then the Daily Sheets to print and use.

CHAPTER 10

The Decree Against Debt

✦

Debt is the heaviest thing a house can carry. It wakes you at night and follows you into every store. The Torah has something to say about it that most people have never been told, and it is more honest than any promise that debt will simply vanish.

The year of release

In the Book of Deuteronomy, Moses gives a law that sounds almost impossible:

> *"At the end of every seven years thou shalt make a release. And this is the manner of the release: Every creditor that lendeth ought unto his neighbour shall release it; he shall not exact it of his neighbour, or of his brother; because it is called the LORD'S release." (Deuteronomy 15:1-2)*

The Hebrew word is *shemitah*, "release," or "letting go." Every seventh year, a lender in Israel had to let go of what his neighbor owed him.

DEUTERONOMY 15:2

כִּי־קָרָא שְׁמִטָּה לַיהוָה

Ki kara shemitah laAdonai.

KEE · kah-RAH · sh'mee-TAH · lah-ah-doh-NYE

"Because it is called the LORD'S release."

What the release is, and what it isn't

Let's be honest about this verse, because many people have been told something it doesn't say.

The release in Deuteronomy is a law for the **lender**. It tells the one who lent money to let it go. It is not a law that lets a borrower stop paying today. And the Jewish sages had to deal with a problem it caused. The Mishnah, in tractate Sheviit (10:3), tells that Hillel the Elder saw people refusing to lend to each other as the seventh year came close, because they were afraid of losing their money. So he set up the *prozbul*, a document that let a loan be collected after the seventh year, so the poor could still borrow.

So what does this verse give you, if you owe money?

1. **It tells you debt was never meant to be forever.** Hashem built an end into the Torah's system of lending. A life sentence of debt is not His design.
2. **It calls the release "the LORD'S."** Release belongs to Hashem. You can ask Him for it, and you can work toward it.
3. **It shows you which side to be on.** One day, you want to be the one who lends and lets go, not the one who owes.

And the rest of the Bible tells you how the righteous handle a debt while they have it:

> *"The wicked borroweth, and payeth not again: but the righteous sheweth mercy, and giveth." (Psalm 37:21)*

> *"The borrower is servant to the lender." (Proverbs 22:7)*

Think back to the widow in Chapter 2. When the oil came, Elisha didn't tell her the debt was gone. He told her: "Go, sell the oil, and pay thy debt, and live thou and thy children of the rest." The miracle didn't cancel the debt. It paid it. That's the pattern for you.

The Decree Against Debt

Say this once a day, at the moment you chose for the seven days, for as long as you carry the debt.

THE DECREE AGAINST DEBT

Hashem, release belongs to You. You did not make me to be a servant to a lender forever. I don't run from what I owe. I will pay it, piece by piece, with honest hands. Open the way for each debt to end, one by one, and let me live, and my children, of the rest. Make me one day the one who lends, and lets go. Ki kara shemitah laAdonai.

The plan of release

The decree is the prayer. Here is the work that goes with it.

STEP BY STEP

1. Take out the folder from Day 1. On a clean page write "My debts," and list every one: who you owe, how much, the monthly payment, and the interest rate if you know it.
2. Stop adding. For the length of this plan, no new debt for anything that isn't food, medicine or keeping a roof and heat. Put the credit card somewhere hard to reach.
3. Never borrow to pay a debt, unless it's a clear, written lower-cost plan you fully understand. Be very careful of anyone who calls offering to "erase" your debt for a fee.
4. Pay the minimum on every debt, every month, on time. That keeps the house standing.
5. Choose one debt to finish first. Many people start with the smallest, so they see one end quickly. Others start with the one that charges the most interest. Pick one and write its name at the top of the page.

6. Every extra dollar, from the leaks you closed, from your envelope, from anything you sold, goes to that one debt.
7. When it's paid, write "RELEASED" across it in big letters, say "Ki kara shemitah laAdonai," and give thanks. Then move to the next one.

HOLD ON

If a collector calls, you don't have to agree to anything on the phone. Ask them to send the details in writing. Never give your bank account number to a collector who called you. If you're sued, or can't keep up even with minimum payments, look for a nonprofit credit counseling service and ask them for help before you sign anything.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

Write "RELEASED" big. You'll want to see it again on a hard day. Every one you finish is a small year of release in your own house.

Be the one who releases

There's one more way to keep this verse, and almost no one thinks of it. Is there someone who owes *you* money? A small loan to a relative, a neighbor, a friend who never paid it back?

If you can afford to, let one of them go. Tell them plainly: "That money you owe me, consider it released." You'll be doing, in a small way, exactly what Deuteronomy asks of the lender. And you'll have shut one more door to bitterness in your house.

BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

- [ ] I wrote the full list of my debts.
- [ ] I chose the one debt to finish first and wrote it at the top.
- [ ] I said the Decree Against Debt.
- [ ] I put my credit card somewhere hard to reach.
- [ ] I thought about whether there's a small debt I can release for someone else.



When a debt is paid, write "RELEASED" across it in big letters.

CHAPTER 11

When the Money Comes: Silence and Tzedakah

✦

Sooner or later, money comes in. A check you didn't expect, a refund, a bill smaller than you feared, a little extra at the end of the month. What you do in that first hour decides whether it stays. The tradition teaches two things: keep quiet, and give.

The blessing hides

The Talmud has a teaching that is said twice, in tractate Taanit (8b) and again in tractate Bava Metzia (42a). Rabbi Yitzchak says:

> *"Blessing is found only in what is hidden from the eye."*

He learns it from the verse in Deuteronomy we read in Chapter 1: "The LORD shall command the blessing upon thee in thy storehouses." A storehouse is closed. What's inside isn't on display.

Then the Talmud gives a picture. A farmer goes out to measure the grain on his threshing floor. Before he begins, he prays. Here are the Talmud's words for his prayer:

> *"May it be Your will, Lord our God, that You send blessing upon the work of our hands."*

After he's started measuring, he says, "Blessed is He who sends a blessing upon this pile." But the Talmud warns: if he measured first and prayed afterward, his prayer is in vain, because a blessing isn't found in what has already been weighed, measured or counted. It's found in

what is hidden.

What silence means in practice

Silence doesn't mean secrets from your spouse, and it doesn't mean you never look at your bank balance. You must know your numbers to manage a house. It means this:

- **Don't announce it.** When money comes, you don't need to tell the neighbors, post it or brag to the family.
- **Pray before you count.** When a check comes or a payday arrives, say the farmer's prayer first, then count.
- **Keep your envelope closed.** The envelope or jar in your drawer from Chapter 2 isn't for counting every night. Put money in, shut the drawer.
- **Let the bird fly empty.** Just as you don't curse the rich in your bedroom, you don't boast in it either.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

Ecclesiastes said the bird carries the voice. It carries boasting as easily as cursing. When something good comes, thank Hashem out loud and tell the world quietly, or not at all.

Then give

The second half of this chapter is the oldest money teaching in the Bible: give a part of what comes in.

> *"Honour the LORD with thy substance, and with the firstfruits of all thine increase: So shall thy barns be filled with plenty." (Proverbs 3:9-10)*

> *"There is that scattereth, and yet increaseth." (Proverbs 11:24)*

The Talmud goes further. In tractate Taanit (9a), Rabbi Yochanan reads the Torah's command, "Thou shalt truly tithe" (Deuteronomy 14:22). In Hebrew it's a doubled word, *aser te'aser*. He explains it with a play on words: "Tithe, so that you will become rich." A boy asks him how he knows, and Rabbi Yochanan says: "Go and test it."

The boy objects: isn't it forbidden to test Hashem? And the Talmud answers that it is forbidden in every case but one. The one exception is giving, because of the prophet Malachi:

> *"Bring ye all the tithes into the storehouse... and prove me now herewith, saith the LORD of hosts, if I will not open you the windows of heaven, and pour you out a blessing, that there shall not be room enough to receive it." (Malachi 3:10)*

A tithe is a tenth. The Talmud ties that tenth to becoming rich, and Malachi calls it the one place where Hashem says "prove me."

PROVERBS 10:2

וּצְדָקָה תַּצִּיל מִמָּוֶת

Utzedakah tatzil mimavet.

oo-tz'dah-KAH · tah-TZEEL · mee-MAH-vet

"But righteousness delivereth from death."

The Hebrew word the King James translates "righteousness" is *tzedakah*, the same word Jews use for charity. In tractate Bava Batra (10a) the Talmud reads it exactly that way: charity saves from death. Giving isn't a cost of the blessing. It's part of it.

HOLD ON

Give from what comes in, not from what you owe. If the rent and the medicine aren't covered, start with a coin. A coin given with a whole heart keeps the habit alive until there's more. Never give to anyone who promises you money back in return for your gift. That is not tzedakah. That's a sale, and often a scam.

The first hour: what to do when money comes

STEP BY STEP

1. Before you count it, say the farmer's prayer: "May it be Your will, Lord our God, that You send blessing upon the work of our hands."
2. Set aside the giving first. A tenth, if you can. If you can't, a smaller part. Even a coin.
3. Then look at your rain calendar and your debt list. Put the rest where it belongs: the bill that's due, the one debt you're finishing, the envelope in the drawer.
4. Tell the people in your house who need to know. Nobody else.
5. Say "thank You" out loud: "Pote'ach et yadecha, umasbia lechol chai ratzon."

Where to give

Tzedakah goes where it helps. Some simple places:

- A person you know who's in need, given quietly, so they're not embarrassed.
- A food pantry or soup kitchen near you.
- The fund for the needy at your synagogue or your congregation.
- A small tin box, a *pushke*, at home. Put coins in it during the week, and give what's in it when it's full.

THE PRACTICAL SIDE

A small charity box on the kitchen counter turns giving into a daily habit. Drop a coin in before you say the psalm in the morning, the way Rabbi Elazar gave before he prayed. Give the coin you set aside on Day 7 this week.

BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

- [ ] I know the farmer's prayer, to say before counting.
- [ ] I decided what part of what comes in I will give.
- [ ] I chose where I'll give.
- [ ] I gave the coin I set aside on Day 7.
- [ ] I put a small charity box, or a jar for giving, in my kitchen.



A small charity box on the counter turns giving into a daily habit.



What comes in, guard in silence. Then give.

APPENDIX

The Daily Sheets

✦

Print one sheet for each day, or copy the lines into your notebook. Keep them in a folder by your bed. A pencil works best.

Day 1 · Psalm 112 · Morning

THE WORDS

Hon va'osher beveito, vetzidkato omedet la'ad.

DAY 1

- [ ] Read Psalm 112 aloud
- [ ] Said the Hebrew words three times
- [ ] Said the Command of Day 1
- [ ] Opened every envelope and wrote the list
- [ ] Wrote today's spending on the leak page

What I asked Hashem for today:

What I did with my hands today:

Day 2 · Psalm 65 · Morning

THE WORDS

Itarta shenat tovatecha, uma'galecha yir'afun dashen.

DAY 2

- [ ] Read Psalm 65 aloud
- [ ] Said the Hebrew words three times
- [ ] Said the Command of Day 2
- [ ] Wrote my rain calendar and circled the dry week
- [ ] Wrote today's spending on the leak page

What I asked Hashem for today:

What I did with my hands today:

Day 3 · Psalm 23 · Bedtime

THE WORDS

Adonai ro'i, lo echsar.

DAY 3

- [ ] Wrote "What I have in the house"
- [ ] Read Psalm 23 aloud
- [ ] Said the Hebrew words three times
- [ ] Said the Command of Day 3
- [ ] Wrote today's spending on the leak page

What I asked Hashem for today:

What I found in the house:

Day 4 · Psalm 91 · Bedtime

THE WORDS

Yoshev beseter Elyon, betzel Shaddai yitlonan.

DAY 4

- [ ] Wrote my money fear and its first step
- [ ] Said the snare rule out loud
- [ ] Read Psalm 91 aloud
- [ ] Said the Hebrew words three times
- [ ] Said the Command of Day 4
- [ ] Wrote today's spending on the leak page

The fear, and its first step:

What I asked Hashem for tonight:

Day 5 · Psalm 24 · Morning

THE WORDS

LaAdonai ha'aretz umelo'ah, tevel veyoshvei vah.

DAY 5

- [ ] Read Psalm 24 aloud
- [ ] Said the Hebrew words three times
- [ ] Said the Command of Day 5
- [ ] Cancelled at least one repeating charge
- [ ] Wrote the name of anyone I owe, and a plan
- [ ] Wrote today's spending on the leak page

The charge I cancelled, and what it saves:

Who I owe, and my plan:

Day 6 · Psalm 145 · Morning, midday, evening

THE WORDS

Pote'ach et yadecha, umasbia lechol chai ratzon.

DAY 6

- [ ] Read Psalm 145 aloud in the morning
- [ ] Said verse 16 at midday
- [ ] Said verse 16 in the evening
- [ ] Said the Command of Day 6
- [ ] Made the honest call
- [ ] Wrote today's spending on the leak page

Who I called, the date, and what they said:

Day 7 · Psalm 37 · After the evening meal

THE WORDS

Na'ar hayiti gam zakanti, velo ra'iti tzaddik ne'ezav, vezar'o mevakesh lachem.

DAY 7

- [ ] Set aside a coin for tzedakah before praying
- [ ] Read Psalm 37:23–29 aloud
- [ ] Said the Hebrew words three times
- [ ] Said the Command of Day 7
- [ ] Circled the leaks and wrote the three biggest
- [ ] Wrote one good thing I saw this week

The three biggest leaks:

This week I saw...

The Leak Page

Write every dollar that leaves your hands or your account, every evening for seven days.

Day	What went out	Amount	Chosen on purpose?
1			
1			
2			
2			
3			
3			
4			
4			
5			
5			
6			
6			
7			
7			

The Rain Calendar

When money comes into this house, and what is due the same week.

Month	Money comes in (source and day)	Bills due that week
January		
February		
March		
April		
May		
June		
July		
August		
September		
October		
November		
December		

My Plan of Release

Who I owe	Total	Monthly payment	Interest rate	RELEASED (date)

The one I'm finishing first:

The Decree Against Debt (say it daily): *Ki kara shemitah laAdonai.*

A Last Word

✦

Seven days ago you picked up this book because something about money had to change. Look at what you've done since. You opened the envelopes. You learned when your rains come. You counted what Hashem already put in your house. You named a fear and put it down. You cleaned your hands, made an honest call, and gave before you asked.

None of that was magic. All of it was real. And every morning or night, you put it under the words of the psalms, the same words Jews have said in their prayers for a very long time.

What now

- **Keep one psalm.** Choose the day that spoke to you most and keep saying its Hebrew words every day. If you can't choose, keep Day 6, *Pote'ach et yadecha*.
- **Keep the rule of the house.** The card on the refrigerator stays up.
- **Keep the leak page** one more week. Then once a month.
- **Say the Decree Against Debt** until the last debt reads RELEASED.
- **Keep the charity box** on the counter.



RABBI DAVID'S NOTE

If you fall off for a week, don't call it failure. Open the book to Day 1 and begin again. The door you opened is still there.

May Hashem open His hand to you and to your house, and may He crown your year with His goodness. *Yevarechecha Adonai veyishmerecha.* The LORD bless thee, and keep thee. For more teaching, watch **Rabbi David Message** on YouTube.